

Look inside...

THIS MONTH'S COVER STORY IS A LITTLE MORBID, I'll readily admit to that. Especially since it comes at a time when we are all seeing what is happening in Afghanistan. No matter which side of the political fence you pledge your allegiance to, no sane human wants any other innocent human to suffer. We have looked at the cold hard tech of it all, and focussed on informing you about developments in AI and how it will rule the wars of the future, but it's not a topic devoid of emotions.

In fact, nothing can be scarier than the idea of unfeeling, unyielding machines that cannot be reasoned with, bearing down on you and your family, and you helpless to do anything to protect them all. And that is undoubtedly the future we're headed for. Don't be fooled by the Terminator movies and their romanticising of the human spirit, because in the real world, machines designed to kill, will do just that. There aren't going to be Sarah or John Connor's saving the world from killer robots (if they ever turned sentient and decided it was time we went extinct)... Maybe EMP bombing ourselves back to pre-tech times would work, but not much else.

The cover story this month has looked at every domain on the planet that AI and tech will take over – air, land, sea, undersea, and space. This is because we're looking at "AI" as weaponry that causes death and destruction directly. However, there's one battleground where AI (under the command of human masters) has been attacking us all for the past decade or two. And it's been far more successful than a few US drone strikes in poor countries that kill a few people now and then... instead, AI has been used to attack us all – billions of us, all at once.

I'm talking, of course, about the most important battleground of all, the human mind. And it is inside our minds that technology has reached, and with it, has come the influence of AI. We've been so busy being distracted by funny cat videos, that we've not truly taken the time to understand how technology has exposed all of us to something very dangerous. Now, before you tell me to put on my tin foil hat, and accuse me of spreading conspiracy theories about lizard people, hear me out.

For years we have been slaves to the algorithm! And this is not a potshot at Google. Or rather not a potshot at Google alone. Whether it's Facebook, Twitter, Google, Apple,

Netflix, governments, politicians, Amazon, Elon Musk, and even you and me... we're all feeding into the algorithm.

In the late 90s, when I read Richard Dawkins' book, *The Selfish Gene* (written in 1976; 45 years ago!), I didn't even notice the word "meme" in it if I'm honest. It was just a very forgettable placeholder word for an idea he was conveying, and I didn't even understand the idea too well either. I only heard about memetics much later when internet memes took off in the noughties. While serious researchers turn their noses up at memetics, personally, I'm a believer, which is very ironic, because in this column I'm talking about memes as ideas that can propagate across societies and populations based solely on popularity – whether or not they're factual, be damned.

And that's precisely the human weakness that I think AI is exploiting. Of course, current AI is human controlled (I hope!), which is why it is used primarily by large corporations to maximise profits. Whether it's Facebook feeding you more of what you want to see on your timeline, Google showing you exactly what others like you clicked on, or Apple doing it much more quietly by buying up over 20 AI / ML firms, including AI for marketing developers, and poaching away top AI researchers from competitors like Google, because it wants to make its services as irresistible as we find their devices. Then there are governments and politicians spreading (mis?)information by any means necessary to malign opponents, targeted attacks by states against the civilians of other countries, making them in-fight and making them weaker... dividing and ruling.

There are several armies of AIs out there targeting you and your money, your votes, your way of thinking, trying to convert you into their ranks, and most of us don't even realise it or put up barriers to fight back these attacks. Waking up to this reality and questioning every belief you have arrived at over the past 15 years or so is the only way to defend yourself from the algorithms.

Think about that the next time you find your blood pressure rising when you see an online post designed to trigger you, or the next time your hands are itching to buy something shiny and new, because you see a video designed to make you desire it. Look inside... question yourself. **d**



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